

Chapter# 02

Wahi (Revelation) of the Holy Qur'an

- Meaning of *Wahi*
- Various classifications and procedure of *Wahi*
- Stages of revelation of the Holy Qur'an
- Gradual revelation of the Holy Qur'an and the wisdom behind it
- The First and the Last Revelation.

The meaning of Wahy

- **Linguistic meaning:**

The term “*wahy*” in Arabic means a swift and or secretive transfer of information. It has been used in a number of places in the Qur'an to indicate the following meanings:

- Natural human instincts that Allaah has placed in humans. Allah says in this regard:

- وَأَوْحَيْنَا إِلَىٰ أُمِّ مُوسَىٰ أَنْ أَرْضِعِيهِ - القصص-7

- Intuition; a person gets a strong feeling that a certain action is the right to do ,even though there may not any logical evidence for it. Allah says:

- فَإِذَا خِفتَ عَلَيْهِ فَأَلْقِيهِ فِي الْيَمِّ وَلَا تَخَافِي وَلَا تَحْزَنِي - القصص-7

- Instinctual animal habits. The Quran says:

- وَأَوْحَىٰ رَبُّكَ إِلَى النَّحْلِ أَنْ اتَّخِذِي مِنَ الْجِبَالِ بُيُوتًا وَمِنَ الشَّجَرِ وَمِمَّا يَعْرِشُونَ - النحل-68

- The natural order and laws of nature. For example Allah says:

- فَقَضَاهُنَّ سَبْعَ سَمَوَاتٍ فِي يَوْمَيْنِ وَأَوْحَىٰ فِي كُلِّ سَمَاءٍ أَمْرَهَا - فصلت-12

- “

The meaning of Wahy

- Communication by rapid, subtle gestures. Allaah said about the Prophet Zakareeyaa:
- فَخَرَجَ عَلَى قَوْمِهِ مِنَ الْمِحْرَابِ فَأَوْحَىٰ إِلَيْهِمْ أَنْ سَبِّحُوا بُكْرَةً وَعَشِيًّا
- The process of Allah's command to the angels. The Quran says:
- إِذْ يُوحِي رَبُّكَ إِلَى الْمَلَائِكَةِ أَنِّي مَعَكُمْ فَثَبَّتُوا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا - الانفال-12
- The whispering and prodding of the devils. Allah says:
- ”وَإِنَّ الشَّيَاطِينَ لَيُوحُونَ إِلَىٰ أَوْلِيَائِهِمْ لِيُجَادِلُوكُمْ - الانعام-121
- The process of revelation of Allah's commands to His Prophet , as well as the revelation itself. A good example of this use is in the following verse:
- وَمَا يَنْطِقُ عَنِ الْهَوَىٰ (3) إِنْ هُوَ إِلَّا وَحْيٌ يُوحَىٰ (4)-النجم

The meaning of Wahy

- Technical Meaning : In the terminology of the *Sharee'ah*, *wahy* is defined as the process by which Allah's word is revealed to one of His prophets. It is also used for the actual word of Allah which has been revealed to one of His prophets

The Methods /Procedures/Classifications of *Wahy*

- Allah's word may be revealed to the prophets in two ways:
Directly, in the form of true dreams or in the form of direct conversations; and

- **Indirectly, by way of the angel of revelation, Jibreel.**

These ways were identified by Allah in the Qur'an as follows:

- وَمَا كَانَ لِنَبِيٍّ أَنْ يَكْلِمَهُ اللَّهُ إِلَّا وَحْيًا أَوْ مِنْ وَرَاءِ حِجَابٍ أَوْ يُرْسِلَ رَسُولًا فَيُوحِيَ بِإِذْنِهِ مَا يَشَاءُ إِنَّهُ عَلَىٰ حَكِيمٍ-الشورى-51

- “Allaah does not speak to a person except by inspiration (*wahy*), or from behind a veil or by sending a messenger who then reveals (*yoohee*) by His permission whatever He wishes. Verily, He is most High and Wise.”

- **Direct Revelations**

A portion of Allaah's revelation was communicated directly to the prophets without any intermediary. This form of revelation came **either as visions during a prophet's sleep, or in the form of words spoken by Allaah from behind a veil of light.**

The Method /Procedure/Classifications of Wahy

- True Dreams:

Divine commands were communicated to the prophets in their sleep in the form of dreams that gave them accurate glimpses of future events. Aa'ishah, said, *"Revelation to the Prophet (SAAS) first began as righteous visions in his sleep. Whenever he saw a vision, it would occur as surely as the break of the day."* This form of revelation was a very gentle means of preparing the Prophet (r) for the tremendous burden of revelation in the waking state. Sometimes visions directed the prophets to perform certain acts, as in the case of Prophet Ibraaheem, who is recorded in the Qur'aan as saying to his son Ismaa'eel,

- فَلَمَّا بَلَغَ مَعَهُ السَّعْيَ قَالَ يَا بُنَيَّ إِنِّي أَرَىٰ فِي الْمَنَامِ أَنِّي أَذْبَحُكَ
فَانْظُرْ مَاذَا تَرَى الصافات-102

- "O my dear son, verily, I saw in dream that I am to sacrifice you. What is your opinion?"

The Method /Procedure/Classifications of *Wahy*

Ismaa'eel's reply is recorded as follows:

- قَالَ يَا أَبَتِ افْعَلْ مَا تُؤْمَرُ سَتَجِدُنِي إِنْ شَاءَ اللَّهُ مِنَ الصَّابِرِينَ-الصفات-102

“O dear father, do as you are commanded. You will find me, Allaah willing, among those who are patient.

Both Prophet Ibraaheem and his son knew that the vision was a divine command which they had to fulfill. The only *soorah* of the Qur'aan reported to have been revealed in a vision was *Soorah al-Kawthar*. The *sahaabee* Anas ibn Maalik said, “Once while Allaah’s Messenger (r) was among us in the masjid, he dozed off, then raised his head, smiling. I asked him, ‘What has amused you, O Messenger of Allaah (r)?’ He replied, ‘A *soorah* has just been revealed to me.’ Then he recited, ‘In the

- name of Allaah, the Most Compassionate, the Most Merciful,

إِنَّا أَعْطَيْنَاكَ الْكَوْثَرَ (1) فَصَلِّ لِرَبِّكَ وَانْحَرْ (2) إِنَّ شَانِئَكَ هُوَ الْأَبْتَرُ (3)

- “Verily, I have given you *Kawthar* (the fountain in paradise) so pray to your Lord and sacrifice. Verily, it is your enemy who will be cut off.”

The Method /Procedure/Classifications of *Wahy*

- **Divine Speech:**

The second method of direct communication by Allaah with His prophets took the form of direct speech, in which the actual words of Allaah were spoken to the prophets. In this case, the prophets were in a waking state, but a veil of light separated them from Allaah and prevented them from seeing Him. This form of communication only occurred with two prophets, as far as we know. The first of those was Prophet Moosaa, about whom Allaah stated the following in the Qur'aan:

- وَلَمَّا جَاءَ مُوسَىٰ لِمِيقَاتِنَا وَكَلَّمَهُ رَبُّهُ

“And when Moosaa came to Our appointed place and his Lord spoke to him...”

- This method of communication was apparently the main way in which Prophet Moosaa received revelation, hence his title “*Kaleemullah*” (the one to whom Allaah spoke). The second prophet to listen to the direct speech of Allaah was Prophet Muhammad (SAAS). However, this phenomenon occurred on only one occasion during his prophet hood; at the time of the Prophet’s ascension up into the heavens (*Mi‘raaj*)

The Method /Procedure/Classifications of *Wahy*

- **Indirect Revelation**

The vast majority of Allaah's revelation was conveyed to the prophets by way of the angel of revelation, Jibreel. The final book of revelation, the Qur'aan, was revealed in this way for the most part. This form of revelation reached the Prophet (SAAS) in two ways: either in the form of the reverberating sound like the gong of a bell, or in the form of the direct speech of the angel.

In the first case, the angel remained in a spiritual state and the Prophet (SAAS) was required to raise spiritually to a suitable state in which to receive the revelation. This method was extremely taxing on the Prophet (SAAS). During it the voice of the angel resembled the loud ringing of a giant bell. The *sahaabee* al-Haarith ibn Hishaam once asked the Prophet (SAAS) to describe how the revelation came to him. The Prophet (r) replied,

- أَحْيَانًا يَأْتِينِي مِثْلَ صَلْصَلَةِ الْجَرَسِ وَهُوَ أَشَدُّ عَلَيَّ فَيُفْصِمُ عَنِّي وَقَدْ وَعَيْتُ عَنْهُ مَا قَالَ

The Method /Procedure/Classifications of *Wahy*

- *“Sometimes it comes to me like the ringing of a bell—this is the most severe form for me—then the ringing ceases and I have understood what (the angel) said.”*
- ‘Aa’ishah described the intensity of this form as follows: “I have seen him when revelation (*wahy*) descended upon him on an extremely cold day, yet when it stopped his forehead would be dripping with sweat.”
- The second method was much easier for the Prophet (SAAS) to bear than the first. In this case, the angel would leave the spiritual world, appear to the Prophet (SAAS) in human form and pass on the revelation in the medium of human speech. The Prophet (SAAS) described this form to al-Haarith ibn Hishaam as follows:
 - وَأَحْيَانًا يَتَمَثَّلُ لِي الْمَلَكُ رَجُلًا فَيُكَلِّمُنِي فَأَعِي مَا يَقُولُ
 - “Occasionally the angel appears before me in the form of a man and speaks to me, and I grasp all that he says.”

Stages of Revelation

The holy Quran was revealed in three distinct stages, to the vast majority of scholars:

- **The First stage:**

The Quran was written on the *Lauh al Mahfoodh* (The preserved Tablet) which is with Allah. But how and when it was written is known only to Allah. He says in this regard:

- **بَلْ هُوَ قُرْآنٌ مَّجِيدٌ (21) فِي لَوْحٍ مَحْفُوظٍ (22)**

Nay! This is indeed a glorious Quran. (Inscribed) in the *Lauh al Mahfoodh*. (Al Buroj, 21-22)

- The wisdom behind this stage of revelation of Quran is to show the believers its authenticity that it was written down even before its revelation in a place which guarantees safety and where everything –small or big will happen from the creation of earth and heaven until the end of the time is recorded. This is also a manifestation of the infinite knowledge of Allah.

Stages of Revelation

The second Stage:

- From *Lauh al Mahfoodh*, Allah revealed The Quran to the heaven closer to earth, in a place called “The House of Honor” (*Baitul Izzah*). This revelation occurred in Ramdan on the Night of decree. The Quran states:
- شَهْرُ رَمَضَانَ الَّذِي أُنْزِلَ فِيهِ الْقُرْآنُ - The month of Ramdan is the month in which the Quran was revealed.....(Al Baqarah, 185)

It also states, إِنَّا أَنْزَلْنَاهُ فِي لَيْلَةٍ مُبَارَكَةٍ

We revealed it on a blessed night.....(Ad- Dukhan,3)

In explanation of the verses Ibn Abbas says: The whole Quran was sent down to the lower heaven on the night of decree. The place the Quran was revealed to was “Baitul Izzah”

Stages of Revelation

The third stage:

- This is final stage of the revelation of Quran. The angel Gabriel brought it to Prophet Mohammad SAAS in piecemeal fashion catering the needs of human begins. Allah says:
- **وَإِنَّهُ لَتَنْزِيلُ رَبِّ الْعَالَمِينَ (192) نَزَلَ بِهِ الرُّوحُ الْأَمِينُ (193) عَلَى قَلْبِكَ لِتَكُونَ مِنَ الْمُنْذِرِينَ (194) بِلِسَانٍ عَرَبِيٍّ مُبِينٍ**
- And indeed, the Qur'an is the revelation of the Lord of the worlds. The Trustworthy Spirit has brought it down upon your heart, [O Muhammad] - that you may be of the warners - In a clear Arabic language. (Ash Shuara, 192-94)
- Ibn Abbas says:"Then whenever Allah wished to inspire something (from Quran), He would inspire". In another narration: ..."it was then revealed piece meal over a period of twenty years".
- This gradual revelation took place over a period of twenty three years, according to the strongest opinion. Some say twenty years and yet other group twenty five

Revelation of Quran to the angel

We know that Allah (SWT) revealed the Quran by way of angel of revelation, Gibrael .But the scholars have difference of opinion as to how Gibrael took the Quran from Allah (SWT).

- Ahl as- Sunnah wa-Al Jam'ah believes that the Quran is the speech of Allah which can be heard . Allah spoke the Quran to Gibrael in a manner that is befitting Him, not similar or comparable to human speech. In other words , Gibrael heard the Quran from Allah (SWT) directly.

- قَالَ رَسُولُ اللَّهِ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ إِذَا تَكَلَّمَ اللَّهُ بِالْوَحْيِ سَمِعَ أَهْلُ السَّمَاءِ لِلْسَّمَاءِ صَلَاحٌ كَجَرِّ السَّلْسِلَةِ عَلَى الصِّفَاءِ فَيَصْعَقُونَ فَلَا يَزَالُونَ كَذَلِكَ حَتَّى يَأْتِيَهُمْ جِبْرِيلُ حَتَّى إِذَا جَاءَهُمْ جِبْرِيلُ فَنَزَعَ عَنْ قُلُوبِهِمْ قَالُوا فَيَقُولُونَ يَا جِبْرِيلُ مَاذَا قَالَ رَبُّكَ فَيَقُولُ الْحَقُّ فَيَقُولُونَ الْحَقُّ الْحَقُّ

The Prophet (SAW)said;“When Allaah, the Most High, speaks the revelation (wahy), the inhabitants of heaven hear the heavens tremble with a sound like the rattling of a chain across a smooth stone. They are stunned and faint, and they remain in that state until Jibreel comes to them. When Jibreel comes to them, the fear is removed from their hearts. They say, ‘O Jibreel! What did your Lord say?’ He says, ‘The truth.’ Then they say, ‘The truth, the truth.’ ”

This Hadith is explicit in that Allah speaks to him with inspiration.

Revelation of Quran to the angel

- Apart from the proofs from Quran and Sunnah, there exists narrations from such scholars as Imam Ahmad, al-Bukharee and al-Byhaqee.
- Imam Ahmad said: Jibreel heard the Quran from Allah (SWT), Mohammad (SAW) heard the Quran from Jibreel, the companions heard the Quran from Mohammad (SAW). Therefore, the Quran is not created.
- Imam Al-Bayhaqee Said in explaining the verse,
- **إِنَّا أَنْزَلْنَاهُ فِي لَيْلَةِ الْقَدْرِ**
- “Verily, We have revealed it in the Night Decree”
- This verse means –and Allah knows best-We made our angel hear it and understand, and revealed with him what he heard, and so the angel descended with the revelation from a higher place (the skies) to a lower one (the earth).

Revelation of Quran to the angel

- Some scholars claimed that Gibreel took the Quran from Lauh Mahfoodh. They mentioned the following verses as their evidence:

- **بَلْ هُوَ قُرْآنٌ مَّجِيدٌ (21) فِي لَوْحٍ مَحْفُوظٍ (22)**

Nay, this is a glorious Quran,(Inscribed) in a Tablet Preserved.

However, these verses do not explicitly mention that Gibreel took the Quran from Lauh Mahfoodh.

- Other scholars, primary those of **Ash'arees**, claimed that Jibreel was inspired the meaning of the Quran but the wording either from Jibreel or Mohammad(SAW).

This opinion is rejected outright, for its adherents deny what Allah has affirmed for Himself, namely that the Quran is His speech that He spoke in a manner or way that befits Him. To say that the wording of the Quran is from Jibreel or Mohammad denies the whole concept of kalam (speech)of Allah, and the miraculous nature of the Quran. Infact ,this type of inspiration for Sunnah of Prophet only and not for the Quran.

Wisdom behind gradual revelation

- There is some wisdom behind the revelation of Quran in gradual manner which are as follows:
- **To strengthen the resolve of the prophet**
- **To make easy memorization and understanding of Quran**
- **To prove the truthfulness of Prophet (SAAS)**
- **To reveal the laws of Islam in gradual manner**
- **To ease the revelation process on the Prophet (SAAS)**

Wisdom behind gradual revelation

- **To strengthen the resolve of the prophet:** The disbelievers of the time of the Prophet SAAS ridiculed him and claimed that he was a soccer, a crazy man or that he was possessed by the Jinn. He was distressed for their mockery. But Allah reaffirmed in his determination and zeal by the continual revelation of Quran. This is what Allah alludes in the Quran. He says:

وَقَالَ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا لَوْلَا نُزِّلَ عَلَيْهِ الْقُرْآنُ جُمْلَةً وَاحِدَةً كَذَلِكَ لِيُثَبِّتَ
بِهِ فُؤَادَكَ وَرَتَّلْنَاهُ تَرْتِيلًا (32)

And those who disbelieve say, "Why was the Qur'an not revealed to him all at once?" Thus [it is] that We may strengthen thereby your heart. And We have spaced it distinctly. (Al Furqan-32)

Wisdom behind gradual revelation

- **To make easy memorization and understanding of Quran:** The piecemeal revelation of the Quran made it easier for the companions to understand, memorize and implement the portions that were revealed. If the Quran had been all at once, it might have been difficult for the companions to understand all of its verses properly. Yet with gradual revelation, the companions understood and implemented the Quran correctly.
- **To prove the truthfulness of Prophet SAAS:** The idolaters and the people of book used to ask the prophet SAAS questions in order to outwit him but every time Allah would reply to their queries. Whenever a situation or crisis arose, the Quran would clearly lay out the situation. Allah says:

قَدْ سَمِعَ اللَّهُ قَوْلَ الَّتِي تُجَادِلُكَ فِي زَوْجِهَا وَتَشْتَكِي إِلَى اللَّهِ وَاللَّهُ
يَسْمَعُ تَحَاوُرَكُمَا إِنَّ اللَّهَ سَمِيعٌ بَصِيرٌ

Wisdom behind gradual revelation

Certainly has Allah heard the speech of the one who argues with you, [O Muhammad], concerning her husband and directs her complaint to Allah. And Allah hears your dialogue; indeed, Allah is Hearing and Seeing. (Al Mujadalah-1)

- **To prove the miraculous nature of the Quran:** One of the most outstanding miracles of the Quran was that it was revealed over a period of two decades catering a plethora of situations and commanding the Prophet SAAS and the believers to a course of action yet not a single of its six thousand plus verses is contradicted by another. To add to miraculous nature, the order and arrangement of verses were not done chronologically, rather the prophet would instruct his companions of the location of any new verse. The Quran was literally assembled out of the fragmental revelation.

Wisdom behind gradual revelation

- **To reveal the laws of Islam in gradual manner:**
Among the blessings of Allah for human being is that He revealed to them the laws of Islam gradually and thus made it easier for them to adopt these laws.
- **To ease the revelation process on the Prophet (SAAS):** The process of *wahi* was a difficult one for the Prophet SAAS .At times he use to sweat profusely, even on a cold night , because of the severity of the inspiration. Had the Quran been revealed all at once, it might have been too difficult for the Prophet SAAS to bear.

First Revelation

- There are four opinions regarding first revelation that Prophet (SAAS) received.

- **First five verses of Surah Al-`Alaq:**

اقْرَأْ بِاسْمِ رَبِّكَ الَّذِي خَلَقَ (1) خَلَقَ الْإِنْسَانَ مِنْ عَلَقٍ (2) اقْرَأْ وَرَبُّكَ
الْأَكْرَمُ (3) الَّذِي عَلَّمَ بِالْقَلَمِ (4) عَلَّمَ الْإِنْسَانَ مَا لَمْ يَعْلَمْ

Recite in the name of your Lord who Created man from a clinging substance. Recite, and your Lord is the most Generous who taught by the pen. Taught man that which he knew not.(96:1-5)

The proof for this opinion is the hadith narrated by Al Bukhari from Aaisha (R) in which she said: The commencement of the Divine Inspiration to Allah's Messenger (SAAS) was in the form of good dreams which came true like bright daylight, and then the love of seclusion was bestowed upon him.

First Revelation

- He used to go in seclusion in the cave of Hira where he used to worship (Allah alone) continuously for many days before his desire to see his family. He used to take with him the food for the stay and then come back to (his wife) Khadija to take his food likewise again till suddenly the Truth descended upon him while he was in the cave of Hira. The angel came to him and asked him to read. The Prophet (SAAS) replied, "I do not know how to read." The Prophet (SAAS) added, "The angel caught me (forcefully) and pressed me so hard that I could not bear it any more. He then released me and again asked me to read and I replied, 'I do not know how to read.' Thereupon he caught me again and pressed me a second time till I could not bear it any more. He then released me and again asked me to read but again I replied, 'I do not know how to read (or what shall I read)?' Thereupon he caught me for the third time and pressed me, and then released me and said: 'Read in the name of your Lord.....'

First Revelation

- **Surah Al-Muddathir:**

The proof for this is based on another hadith in al Bukhari, in which Jabir ibn Abdillah was asked “what part of the Quran was revealed first?” He replied: **يَا أَيُّهَا الْمُدَّثِّرُ** (Shura Muddathir) was revealed first. The questioner then said: I was informed that it was **اقْرَأْ بِاسْمِ رَبِّكَ**. Jabir replied: I am only telling you that which I heard from Prophet (SAAS), for he said: "While I was walking, all of a sudden I heard a voice from the sky. I looked up and saw the same angel who had visited me at the cave of Hira' sitting on a chair between the sky and the earth. I got afraid of him and came back home and said, 'Wrap me (in blankets).' And then Allah revealed **يَا أَيُّهَا الْمُدَّثِّرُ** (O You enveloped).

This hadith actually means which Surah was revealed first in its entirety or after the pause of revelation. It does not mean that it was revealed first

First Revelation

- **Surah Fatihah:**

There was a narration in al -Byhaqee that states the first revelation was Surah al-Fatiha. However this narration is not authentic, there it does not hold any weight.

- **Basmalah (Bismillahir Rahmanir Rahim):**

Another hadith states the first verse revealed was *basmalah* but this hadith too is not authentic and can't be taken as proof

The last revelation

There are a number of opinions concerning the last revelation:

- Al -Bukhari and Tabrani narrate from Ibn Abbas that the last verse revealed to Prophet(SAAS) was
- **وَاتَّقُوا يَوْمًا تُرْجَعُونَ فِيهِ إِلَى اللَّهِ ثُمَّ تُوَفَّى كُلُّ نَفْسٍ مَا كَسَبَتْ وَهُمْ لَا يُظْلَمُونَ**

And fear a Day when you will be returned to Allah. Then every soul will be compensated for what it earned, and they will not be treated unjustly.(2:281)

- Another narration, also by Bukhari from Ibn abbas states that the last verse revealed was the “Verse of Interest”
 - **يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا اتَّقُوا اللَّهَ وَذَرُوا مَا بَقِيَ مِنَ الرِّبَا إِن كُنتُمْ مُؤْمِنِينَ**
- O you who have believed, fear Allah and give up what remains [due to you] of interest, if you should be believers.(2:278)

The last revelation

- “Verse Loaning”.

يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا إِذَا تَدَايْتُمْ يَدَيْنِ إِلَى أَجَلٍ مُّسَمًّى فَاكْتُبُوهُ

O you who have believed, when you contract a debt for a specified time, write it down. (2:282)

- Verse of Khalalah.

يَسْتَفْتُونَكَ قُلِ اللَّهُ يُفْتِيكُمْ فِي الْكَلَالَةِ

They request from you a [legal] ruling. Say, "Allah gives you a ruling concerning one having neither descendants nor ascendants (4:176)

- Last two verses of Surah At –Tawbah.

لَقَدْ جَاءَكُمْ رَسُولٌ مِّنْ أَنْفُسِكُمْ.....

Verily there has come messenger from amongst yourself...(9:18-129)

The last revelation

- Surah An-Nasr:

- The last was

وَمَنْ يَقْتُلْ مُؤْمِنًا مُتَعَمِّدًا فَجَزَاؤُهُ جَهَنَّمُ خَالِدًا فِيهَا

But whoever kills a believer intentionally - his recompense is Hell, wherein he will abide eternally, (4:93)

- Surah Al-Maidah.

- Lat verse of Surah Al -Kahaf

- Last revealed was

الْيَوْمَ أَكْمَلْتُ لَكُمْ دِينَكُمْ وَأَتِمَمْتُ عَلَيْكُمْ نِعْمَتِي وَرَضِيتُ لَكُمُ
الْإِسْلَامَ دِينًا